

Five Steps to Financial Wellbeing

something as complex as happiness and wellbeing to a single line of text, but there's so much scope for adaption and expansion in this equation that it doesn't *feel* reductive. It feels like a useful tape measure, a guideline for addressing the deeper issues in our relationship with money and self. Gawdat himself explains how, even with all of the material wealth he could ever wish for, even with a wonderful partner and two perfect children, even with a prestigious job title and huge career success, he spent years of his life incredibly depressed. Every time he would get a new 'toy' – a supercar or an innovative gadget – and the happiness would be so fleeting that he would barely register it. The depression endured even as his home filled with extravagant purchases. Money and possessions were not the answer.

This is fairly well documented, both statistically and anecdotally, and something that I've reflected on myself since seeing such a huge change in my circumstances in a relatively short amount of time. While there's no doubt that the *absence* of pressing financial stress and *reduction* of financial shame have had a material impact on my happiness in that they have removed something that was actively causing me distress and impacting my mental health in a very negative way, having more money available has not magically solved all of my problems. It has not automatically made me feel like a more worthy and fulfilled person, nor has having more cash magically solved any of the issues in my relationship with money. What it has done is given me space to breathe. It's given me more